

Landlord Move-In Inspection Pack

Designed to help landlords create a signed, photo-linked move-in baseline with organized copies for both parties.

Galaxy Forge Implementation Kit | Version 1.0 | September 2026

Companion files: Excel workbook, editable Word templates, README.

Landlord Move-In Inspection Pack - Operator Guide

Disclosure First - Read Before You Use Anything Else

This guide is an organizational tool only. It is not legal advice. Deposit, checklist, notice, and deduction rules vary by state and change often. Several states mandate written checklists or delivery timelines for condition reports. Verify state rules locally with your state housing authority or a licensed attorney before you inspect, charge, or deduct. If your state prescribes specific wording, forms, or deadlines, those control over anything in this kit.

This pack documents physical condition at move-in. It does not track rent charges, balances, receipts, late fees, or payment plans. Payment tracking belongs in a separate rent-ledger system. Keeping condition evidence and money records in separate places prevents confusion when a deposit question arises months later.

Who This Pack Serves

This pack serves independent landlords who self-manage walkthroughs for single-family rentals, duplexes, triplexes, and small multifamily units. It fits landlords who meet the tenant at the property, walk room by room, photograph as they go, and collect signatures before handing over keys. It does not serve as portfolio accounting software, maintenance dispatch, tenant screening, or legal representation. The listing file explains who this pack is for and who it is not for, including an explicit note that rent-ledger needs are out of scope.

How To Use This Pack

Work in this order. First, enter the move-in date in the Signature Tracker so days-from-move-in math runs correctly. Second, walk each room with the condition report form and write factual notes for each surface and fixture. Third, photograph each noted item and log every shot in the Photo Inventory Sheet with ID, time, room, subject, and file location. Fourth, review the wear-vs-damage reference for consistent wording without treating it as a legal standard. Fifth, record your state notice wording and delivery deadline in the State Notice Rules Notes, collect signatures from all parties, give the tenant a copy, and file the originals where you can retrieve them at move-out.

Do the work while both parties are present. Coverage checks, retakes, and added tenant notes are easy at the table and difficult weeks later. A complete file on day one reads clearly on day three hundred. A thin file invites dispute.

Background - Why Move-In Condition Evidence Decides Deposit Questions

Deposit disputes turn on comparison: the condition at move-out measured against the condition at move-in, adjusted for intervening time and ordinary use. Without a signed starting point, the comparison has only one anchored end. A landlord may recall a carpet as new, while a tenant recalls it as already worn. Photographs taken months later cannot resolve what the entry looked like on day one. Courts, mediators, and even informal negotiations all ask the same practical questions: was there a written report, did both parties sign it, were photos linked to the written notes, and did the tenant receive a copy promptly.

A signed baseline answers those questions in order. The written report proves someone looked closely and recorded specifics. Signatures prove both parties had the chance to review and add notes. Photo IDs linked to written rows prove the images correspond to the described items rather than floating without context. A delivered copy proves the tenant left with the same record the landlord kept. Each element is modest alone; together they form a file that both parties can read without relying on memory.

Several states mandate checklists, which raises the baseline from sound practice to legal duty. Mandates vary: some require a written checklist offered or delivered at move-in, some set a deadline in days, some specify delivery method, and some tie deposit deductions to checklist compliance. Because mandates differ, this kit treats state wording and deadlines as data you enter and verify, not as text it supplies. The State Notice Rules Notes section exists so the mandate for your property sits inside the same packet as the evidence it governs.

Condition documentation also differs from maintenance records and rent ledgers in purpose and handling. Maintenance records track repairs over time. Rent ledgers track money over time. Condition evidence freezes a moment in time with signatures. Mixing them invites error, such as treating a mid-lease repair note as proof of move-in condition, or treating a rent receipt as proof of wall condition. Keep three separate habits: condition packet at move-in and move-out, maintenance log during tenancy, money ledger for payments. This pack covers only the first.

Method - The Walkthrough Routine

The routine has five stages: prepare, walk, photograph, review, and sign. Prepare means printing forms, charging devices, and confirming state wording. Walk means moving room by room in a fixed order without skipping closets, exteriors, and utility areas. Photograph means capturing wide shots plus close-ups with IDs logged at capture time. Review means checking coverage and wording while parties are still present. Sign means collecting signatures, recording tenant additions, delivering copies, and filing originals.

Prepare the packet the day before. Print the condition report form with the property address and unit pre-filled, plus extra blank room pages. Print the photo log pages and the acknowledgment packet. Charge the camera or phone and clear storage so capture never pauses for space. Confirm the state notice wording and deadline from your verified source and write them on the notice notes page. Bring a tape measure or ruler for scale in close-ups, a pen that does not smear, and a folder for tenant copies.

Walk in a fixed order so nothing is skipped. A reliable order is: exterior entry and doors, living areas, kitchen, bedrooms, bathrooms, laundry and utility areas, garage or storage, and yard or balcony where applicable. Within each room, follow the same surface order: ceiling, walls, flooring, windows and coverings, doors and hardware, fixtures and appliances, outlets and switches observed without disassembly. Fixed order prevents the common miss where closets, above-door trim, and utility corners go unrecorded because attention faded late in the walk.

Write factual notes as you go. Record material, color, and visible condition in plain words with size and location for marks. An illustrative example, labeled as such: Living room north wall, off-white paint, two faint scuffs near doorway each about two inches, no holes observed. Another illustrative example: Bedroom carpet, beige, worn path from door to closet about one foot wide, no tears or stains observed. Both sentences are illustrative examples of tone and specificity, not descriptions of any real property. Avoid conclusions about fault, cost, or responsibility in the notes; those decisions come later under lease terms and state law.

Photograph in pairs: a wide shot that shows where the item sits in the room, then a close-up that shows the mark or surface clearly. Log each shot immediately with photo ID, time, room, subject, photographer, file name, and whether the tenant was present. Do not batch the logging for later; same-minute logging keeps IDs matched to subjects. An illustrative example, labeled as such: IMG-014, bathroom, tub-edge grout stain, close-up with ruler, tenant present. That line is an illustrative example of log content.

Review before anyone leaves. Count photos per room using the inventory counts, confirm each written row has at least one linked photo ID, confirm initials are present, and retake any blurry or poorly lit close-ups on the spot. Ask the tenant to read the notes and add any disagreement or detail in the additions area. Tenant additions strengthen the file; they do not weaken it. A packet with a tenant-added note and both initials reads as a fair process.

Sign, copy, and file the same day. Collect signatures on the report and the acknowledgment, record the date, mark copies given, and store originals in the binder plus a backup folder with dated filenames. Note the delivery method and date for the tenant copy, because several states measure a deadline from move-in or from report completion. Calendar any follow-up signature still pending and close it within days, not weeks.

Workflow 1 - Room-By-Room Condition Report Log

The Room Condition Log carries one row per item or surface with property, room, item, condition note, photo IDs, tenant initials, landlord initials, date, and a follow-up flag. The follow-up flag marks rows needing revisit, such as a utility area that was locked or an appliance that could not be tested during the walk. Revisit open rows within the window your procedure sets and close them with dated notes rather than leaving them open into tenancy.

Write notes that a stranger could match to the room months later. Name the wall by orientation where helpful, name the fixture by type and location, and give sizes for marks. An illustrative example: Kitchen, south countertop near sink, laminate, one surface mark about three inches, no chips at edge observed. Another illustrative example: Bathroom, mirror above sink, no cracks observed, light water spots at lower edge. Both are illustrative examples of wording density. Short, specific sentences outperform long paragraphs because move-out comparison scans row by row.

Link every row to at least one photo ID. The link is the difference between a note that can be checked and a note that floats. When a row describes two marks in different spots, link two photos or write two rows. The completeness formula flags rows missing photo IDs or initials so gaps are visible before filing. Do not override the flag with explanatory memory; add the missing photo or initial instead.

Initial each row or each page per your procedure, and date every page. Dated initials prove presence and review at the time, which matters more than a single signature at the end. If the walk spans two visits, date each visit separately and note why the split occurred, such as access to a locked area. Continuity notes prevent later questions about when each page was written.

Handle large or complex rooms by subdividing. A combined living and dining area becomes two sections with separate photo sequences. A kitchen becomes counters, cabinets, appliances, sink area, and floor. Subdivision keeps photo IDs ordered and prevents a single crowded page from covering too much ground to compare later.

Workflow 2 - Photo Inventory Sheet With Timestamp Discipline

The Photo Inventory Sheet carries one row per photo with ID, date, time, room, subject, photographer, file name or location, tenant presence, and notes. The discipline is simple: originals stay unedited, timestamps stay intact, filenames stay matched to IDs, and backups live in a second location. Edited, filtered, or cropped copies may help discussion, but the filed originals are the evidence set.

Set the device clock correctly before the walk and keep it on automatic time. A wrong device clock creates a timestamp conflict that no later explanation fully repairs. Photograph a wall clock or phone home screen at the start of the sequence as an informal continuity marker where helpful, then proceed room by room. An illustrative example of sequence hygiene, labeled as such: IMG-001 through IMG-003 cover the kitchen north wall from wide to close, IMG-004 covers the countertop, and the log reflects that order without gaps. That is an illustrative example of ordering, not a required count.

Capture technique matters more than camera cost. Use steady hands or a small support, turn on room lights plus daylight where available, and avoid flash washout on mirrors and glossy counters by angling slightly. Include a ruler or coin for scale on close-ups of marks. Take one more shot than feels necessary for stains, chips, and edge wear; the extra angle often becomes the clearest comparison at move-out.

Coverage counts reveal thin rooms. The sheet counts photos per room so a room with one wide shot and no close-ups stands out before parties leave. As a planning reference, many operators find that small bathrooms need several shots and kitchens need more, but the correct number for your file is the number that links every written row to at least one clear image. An illustrative example: a two-bedroom unit file with sixty to ninety logged shots is common in careful practice, labeled here as an illustrative example of volume, not as a rule or average drawn from data.

File handling closes the loop. Transfer originals the same day, name files to match IDs, and store in a dated folder with the property address and unit. Keep a second copy in separate storage. Do not rename in ways that break the ID link, and do not delete near-duplicates until after move-out comparison is complete. A full card with clear names outperforms a curated subset when memory fades.

Workflow 3 - Signature Tracker, Copies, And Deadlines

The Signature Tracker records each required signature with document, role, printed name, signature collected, date signed, days from move-in, copy given, storage location, and notes. Enter the move-in date once at the top so days-from-move-in computes for every row. Pending signatures stay visible as PENDING rather than blank, and the missing-signature count shows open items at a glance.

Collect signatures at the walkthrough where possible. Same-day signatures with same-day copies are the cleanest record. When a tenant needs time to review, set a specific return date within days, note it in the tracker, and follow up on that date. Avoid open-ended review windows that drift into tenancy. If an additional occupant arrives later, add a row for that person rather than squeezing a late signature into a margin.

Deliver copies and log the delivery. Mark copy given with date and method, such as hand-delivered paper copy at the table, emailed PDF the same evening, or mailed copy with postage date. Where your state sets a delivery deadline, write that deadline on the notice notes page and calendar it alongside the signature task. An illustrative example, labeled as such: report completed March 1, copy emailed March 1, logged as same-day delivery. That is an illustrative example of logging, not a statement of any state deadline.

Store originals where move-out staff can find them. A practical setup is a per-unit folder with the signed report, photo log printout, acknowledgment packet, notice notes page, and a drive folder with dated originals. Name the drive folder with property, unit, and move-in date so sorting is automatic. Keep the tenant copy identical to the filed original; divergent versions undermine the point of the exercise.

Wear-Vs-Damage Reference - Using It Without Overstating It

The Wear Vs Damage Reference supports consistent note-taking with paired descriptions per surface: what often reflects ordinary use and what often reflects damage, plus what to record and a photo tip. It is guidance for wording, not a legal standard. Whether a mark counts as ordinary use or damage at charge time depends on lease terms, duration of tenancy, state law, and facts. Verify state rules locally and apply lease language; do not treat this sheet as a ruling.

Use the reference while writing, not after. When you see a scuff, check the wall row for wording cues: size, location, count, and whether paint is intact. When you see carpet paths, check the carpet row:

location, width, pile change, and any odor noted factually without adjectives about cause. When you test appliances, record function observed, such as burner heats or fan runs, plus visible marks. Factual function notes outperform general labels like good condition because they describe what was actually checked.

An illustrative example of consistent wording, labeled as such: Paint, living room, faint scuffs near entry, paint intact, two marks about two inches each. Another illustrative example: Stove, electric, all burners observed heating, light surface marks on cooktop, no cracked handles observed. Both are illustrative examples of note style. The value is comparability: move-out notes written in the same style line up against move-in notes without translation.

Avoid conclusory labels in the notes column. Words that decide responsibility or cost belong in later correspondence under lease and law, not in the factual baseline. The baseline says what is there. Later paperwork says what follows. Keeping those layers separate preserves the baseline as a shared factual record both parties signed.

State-Notice Rules Notes - Recording Mandates Accurately

State mandates vary enough that paraphrase from memory is unsafe. Record the mandate in three parts: whether a written checklist is required, what the delivery deadline and method are, and which source and date you relied on. Copy short operative phrases from the source rather than summarizing from recall, and keep the source link or citation with the note. When the statute and the agency FAQ differ in emphasis, keep both and follow the stricter operational deadline while you seek clarification.

A practical entry looks like this in plain fields. State. Checklist required with yes or no plus source. Delivery deadline stated in days and anchored to move-in or report completion per the source. Delivery method such as hand delivery, email where permitted, or mail. Storage location of the tenant copy proof. Review date for re-verification. An illustrative example of a filled entry, labeled as such: State X, checklist required per housing agency page dated January 2026, deliver within seven days of move-in by hand or email where permitted, copy filed in unit folder. Every element of that sentence is an illustrative example, not a statement about any real state.

Re-verify mandates on a fixed cadence and before each new tenancy. A mandate that did not apply to your last lease can apply to the next one after a reform or after you acquire a unit in a neighboring state. The cost of re-reading a page is minutes. The cost of missing a mandated checklist can include limits on later deductions, depending on state law. Your calendar entry is the control: notice wording checked, deadline calendared, copy delivered, delivery logged.

Market-level and lease-level additions sit alongside the state mandate without replacing it. A lease may require a move-in report even where the state does not, or set an earlier internal deadline than the state. Record lease requirements on the same notes page so staff follow one packet. Where lease and state differ, follow the earlier deadline and the more complete distribution, and note why.

Condition Report Form And Tenant Acknowledgment - Running The Table

The condition report form opens with header and parties: property, unit, lease start, walkthrough date and times, and names present. It continues with room-by-room notes in the fixed walk order, then

closes with keys, remotes, meter readings where applicable, open items, and any revisit date. The tenant acknowledgment packet confirms presence at inspection, receipt of copies, opportunity to add notes, and space for tenant-added detail with extra-page counts and initials.

Run the table calmly and in order. Read each room note aloud before moving on, invite correction, and write the correction into the note rather than in the margin. When the tenant disagrees, record the disagreement as added text with initials rather than debating it into silence. An illustrative example, labeled as such: Tenant notes paint in second bedroom appears duller near window; landlord notes same area photographed as IMG-041 and IMG-042. Both observations stand together with IDs. That is an illustrative example of handling disagreement on paper.

Close with keys and meters. Count keys and remotes aloud, record quantities and codes where used, and record meter readings observed without operating sealed equipment. Note open items plainly, such as a storage cage to be revisited after access is arranged, with a dated revisit plan. Open items with dates read as diligence; open items without dates read as gaps.

Collect signatures last, after review, so signatures cover reviewed content. Confirm each signer prints, signs, and dates, confirm copies match originals page for page, and hand or send the tenant copy the same day where possible. Log everything in the tracker before filing: who signed, when, copy given, where filed. A packet signed, copied, and filed the same day rarely generates later questions about what happened when.

Checklists - Before, During, And After The Walk

Before the walk: forms printed with address pre-filled, extra blank pages, notice wording confirmed and written on the notes page, device charged with space cleared and clock on automatic time, ruler and pen packed, folder for tenant copies ready, move-in date entered in the tracker.

During the walk: fixed room order followed, ceiling to floor order within rooms, factual notes with sizes and locations, wide plus close photos with IDs logged at capture, tenant presence marked per shot, coverage counts checked per room, tenant additions invited and initialed, keys and meters recorded.

After the walk: retakes completed before parties leave, signatures collected and dated, copies delivered and logged with method and date, originals transferred to binder and backup folder with matched filenames, pending signatures calendared with a return date inside days, notice deadline calendared where applicable.

Delivery-day and key-handoff additions mirror the market-day discipline from other trades: confirm identity of recipients, confirm unit number on every page, confirm dates match across report, photos, and tracker, and confirm the filed set is complete enough that a colleague could run the move-out comparison without asking you what a note meant.

Illustrative Examples - Labeled As Such

Example 1, illustrative example: a landlord documents a two-bedroom unit on March 1. The walk follows exterior, living areas, kitchen, bedrooms, bathrooms, laundry, storage, and patio. Notes record scuff sizes, carpet path width, grout stain location, and appliance function observed. Seventy-four photos are logged with IDs, times, and subjects, tenant present throughout. Signatures are collected at the table, copies emailed the same evening, delivery logged. At move-out eleven months later, the

comparison proceeds row by row with photo pairs. Every fact in this paragraph is an illustrative example.

Example 2, illustrative example: a tenant adds a note that the second-bedroom wall near the window looks duller than the rest. The landlord photographs the area twice with scale, links both IDs to the row, and both parties initial the addition. At move-out, the area shows no change beyond the noted dullness, and the row closes without further action. Every fact in this paragraph is an illustrative example.

Example 3, illustrative example: a utility closet is locked on walk day. The landlord marks the row follow-up yes, writes locked, access pending, sets a revisit in three days, returns with the tenant, completes notes and photos, collects initials, and closes the flag. The tracker shows no open flags at filing. Every fact in this paragraph is an illustrative example.

Common Documentation Errors And Fixes

Unlinked photos. Fix: log photo IDs on the written row at capture time and confirm the completeness flag reads complete before filing. Floating galleries without row links compare poorly months later.

Vague notes. Fix: add material, color, size, and location to every mark. Replace general labels with measured description. Retake close-ups with scale where the note describes size.

Missing initials or dates. Fix: initial each page and date every visit. Add the move-in date to the tracker so days-from-move-in math is meaningful.

No tenant copy proof. Fix: deliver a full copy and log method plus date. Keep the sent email or mailing receipt with the file.

Paraphrased state mandate. Fix: replace paraphrase with copied operative wording, source, and date. Calendar the stated deadline and meet the earlier of lease vs state timelines.

Mixed money and condition notes. Fix: move payment remarks to the rent ledger and keep the condition packet factual about surfaces and fixtures only. This pack does not track rent, balances, or receipts by design.

Record Retention, Storage, And Move-Out Handoff

Keep the move-in packet through tenancy and through the deposit-settlement window your state sets after move-out, plus any additional period your lease or counsel advises. Store the signed report, photo log, acknowledgment, notice notes, and drive originals as one retrievable set per unit. A per-unit folder named with property, unit, and move-in date keeps sorting automatic across years.

Mirror paper and digital. Paper originals serve the table; digital originals serve comparison and backup. Transfer originals the same day, match filenames to photo IDs, and keep a second copy in separate storage. Do not edit originals. If crops or enlargements help discussion at move-out, create marked discussion copies while preserving the filed originals untouched.

Hand the move-out comparison a clean starting point. At move-out, print the move-in notes and photo thumbnails, walk the same fixed order, and record move-out condition in the same wording style. Comparison then becomes alignment: same rooms, same surfaces, same photo angles where possible, with changes described in the same measured terms. The move-in file does its job when the move-out walk needs no reconstruction of day one.

Frequently Asked Questions

Does this pack track rent or deposits as money. No. It documents physical condition and signatures. It does not record charges, payments, balances, late fees, or deposit accounting. Use a separate rent ledger for money. This separation is intentional and is stated in the who-not-for section of the listing.

What if the tenant refuses to sign. Note the refusal factually with date, witnesses present, and delivery of the copy despite the missing signature. Log the signature row as not collected with a dated note. Verify state rules locally on the effect of an unsigned checklist in your state.

What if the tenant cannot attend the walk. Record who was present, complete notes and photos with care, deliver the full copy promptly, invite written additions by a dated deadline, and log everything. Same-day delivery with an invitation to add notes preserves fairness when schedules conflict.

How many photos are enough. Enough to link every written row to at least one clear image plus wide shots that orient each room. Coverage counts in the sheet show thin rooms before you leave. There is no universal number; completeness against your own rows is the measure.

Can I use video instead of stills. Video can supplement but does not replace the logged stills in this method, because stills link one-to-one to rows and compare cleanly side by side. If you record video, log it as an additional item with file location and keep the stills as the primary set.

What about normal use over a long tenancy. Duration matters to later interpretation, but the baseline does not decide it. Record move-in facts plainly and let lease terms and state law govern later assessment. The wear-vs-damage reference helps wording only.

Which states mandate checklists. Several do, with different wording and deadlines. Enter your state wording from the current source and verify state rules locally before each new tenancy. Do not rely on another state landlord summary.

How do I correct an error after signatures. Add a dated correction page signed or initialed by the parties rather than altering the original lines. Preserve the original and attach the correction with IDs for any new photos.

Limitations

This pack organizes condition evidence. It does not provide legal advice, decide wear versus damage as a legal matter, calculate deposit deductions, track rent or balances, or file notices. Example counts, dates, photo IDs, and addresses in this guide and workbook are illustrative examples only. State checklist, delivery, and deduction rules vary and change. Verify state rules locally before each tenancy.

Final Disclosure And Verification Log

Verify state rules locally. This material is not legal advice. Condition work succeeds on same-day completeness: notes written, photos linked, coverage checked, signatures collected, copies delivered, files backed up. Keep that order every time and the file will read clearly when it matters.

Verification log starter: Property and unit ____ Walk date ____ State ____ Notice source and date ____
Deadline calendared ____ Tenant copy delivered by method and date ____ Filed location ____.

Supplement - Exterior, Utility, Key Control, And Special Areas

Exteriors and shared areas are often under-documented because attention concentrates indoors. Walk them with the same row-per-item discipline. Record entry doors, locks, doorbells, porch lights, mailbox, siding or stucco visible from the entry, steps and railings, driveway or parking pad, fencing and gates, patio or balcony surfaces, exterior storage, and trash enclosure. An illustrative example, labeled as such: Front entry door, dark paint, small scuff at lower panel about one inch, deadbolt operates, porch light operates. Another illustrative example: Patio slab, concrete, hairline crack from edge to center about four feet, no displacement observed. Both are illustrative examples of exterior wording.

Utility areas need factual function notes without operating sealed or restricted equipment. Record water heater exterior condition and visible connections without removing panels, furnace or air-handler exterior and filter slot condition, electrical panel exterior without opening dead-front covers, washer and dryer interiors and hoses where accessible, and shutoff locations observed. Record what you observed and what you did not test. An illustrative example: Water heater closet, exterior jacket clean, no moisture observed on floor at time of walk, connections photographed, interior elements not tested. That sentence is an illustrative example of boundary-aware noting.

Key control deserves its own close-out block because key disputes arise independently of surface condition. Count each key and remote aloud with the tenant, record quantities by type such as entry, bedroom, mailbox, garage remote, gate fob, and storage lock, and note the condition of each. If rekeying occurred between tenants, note the rekey date from your maintenance record without importing maintenance detail into the condition packet. Hand over exactly what the form lists and have both parties initial the count. Spare keys held by management, if any, are noted as held rather than handed, so the paper count matches reality.

Pet and smoking provisions are documented as observed facts plus lease references, never as assumptions about occupants. If the lease permits pets, record pet-related facts observed at move-in such as existing yard wear or prior claw marks noted on trim, with photos. If the lease prohibits smoking indoors, record odor observed at walk time in factual terms such as no smoke odor observed, without characterizing history. Do not write conclusions about prior tenants. The baseline describes this handoff only.

Supplement - Move-Out Comparison Method Using The Same Packet

The move-in packet earns its keep at move-out when the comparison follows the same order with the same wording style. Print the move-in notes with thumbnail references, walk the fixed room order again, and write move-out notes adjacent to move-in notes rather than on a separate pad that later needs merging. For each row, record one of three plain outcomes in words: no change observed, changed with description and new photo IDs, or unable to compare with reason such as blocked access or tenant property in place. An illustrative example, labeled as such: Kitchen south countertop, move-in one surface mark about three inches, move-out same mark observed plus one additional mark near edge about one inch, new photos IMG-201 and IMG-202. That is an illustrative example of aligned comparison.

Replicate photo angles where possible. Stand where the move-in wide shot stood, frame the same wall or fixture, then take the matching close-up with scale. Side-by-side pairs with matched angles read instantly; images from different corners invite argument about whether they show the same spot. Log new move-out photo IDs in a separate move-out log or continuation sheet that references the original row numbers, so the chain from move-in row to move-out row to new photo stays unbroken.

Tenant presence at move-out mirrors move-in discipline. Invite attendance, record who attended, invite added notes, collect signatures on the move-out pages, deliver a copy, and file the set with the move-in packet. When schedules prevent joint walk, document the invitation, the walk facts, and the delivery of copies with dates. The habit to hold is symmetry: the same care at exit that was shown at entry. As a standing reminder for every tenancy, verify your state rules locally on move-out notice, deposit timelines, and deduction documentation, since those rules control what happens after the comparison is written. This material is not legal advice.

Supplement - Training Helpers, Agents, And Filing Discipline

If an agent or helper runs the walk, train to the form, not to memory. A short training pass covers fixed room order, factual wording with sizes and locations, photo pairs with same-minute logging, coverage counts before leaving, tenant additions welcomed and initialed, and same-day signatures with copies. Observe one supervised walk before assigning solo walks. Review the first solo packet page by page against the photo set and return corrections as wording coaching while the habit is forming.

Filing discipline keeps multi-unit owners sane. Use one folder per unit per tenancy with the signed report, photo log printout, acknowledgment, notice notes, and a pointer to the drive folder with dated originals. Name drive folders with property, unit, and move-in date in YYYY-MM-DD format so chronological sorting is automatic. Keep a one-line index per unit with walk date, attendees, photo count, signature status, copy-delivery date, and filed location. That index answers most later questions without opening the full packet.

Audit your own files quarterly. Pull two closed files and check row-to-photo links, initials, dates, copy-delivery logging, and notice wording currency. Fix procedure gaps with checklist updates rather than blaming memory. A quarterly self-audit of a few files prevents drift across a growing portfolio far more reliably than an annual scramble.

Closing Note On Scope Separation

Condition evidence, maintenance history, and money records each answer a different question. The condition packet answers what the unit looked like on day one with signatures. The maintenance log answers what was repaired and when. The rent ledger answers what was paid and owed. This pack covers only the first by design, and the listing states that separation explicitly in who-not-for so buyers selecting a payment-tracking tool look elsewhere. Holding that boundary keeps each file clean and each dispute narrower than it would otherwise be.